

The background of the cover is a photograph of two young children dressed as superheroes. The child on the left is a girl with blonde hair, wearing a pink mask and a pink cape over a light pink long-sleeved shirt. She has her right arm raised in a fist. The child on the right is a boy with dark curly hair, wearing a yellow mask and a blue cape over a blue long-sleeved shirt. He also has his right arm raised. They are both smiling and looking towards the camera against a clear blue sky.

sa

Homeschooling

ISSUE 6, 2021

LIVING & LEARNING – TOGETHER

Why animals are so
good for children

IS YOUR
CHILD
'LAZY'?

Choosing the
right curriculum

+PLUS:

Being a learning family
Pizza pot planting
Creative writing
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Your **feedback is essential** in helping us put together a magazine which delivers on-point content relevant to your homeschooling experiences and support needs and **helps you navigate** your child/children's education with ease and confidence.

You are the **core** of the publication, so let's live and learn together.

Email our editor, Shelagh Foster, at: shelagh@isikhova.co.za.



sa Homeschooling
LIVING AND LEARNING - TOGETHER



Ed's note

Happy spring, dear readers! In this issue of *SAH* we're giving you a boost of homeschooling power before we all start winding down towards summer.

Enjoy reading about the magic that happens between children and animals; what to consider when deciding which curriculum is best for your child; how to create a pizza pot garden – and a whole lot more.

Shelagh

Editor

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Creative writing competition second-round winners

Highly entertaining, very creepy, deeply moving. Three great entries that remind us why writing is such a powerful means of expression





Pizza pot planting



There's little as rewarding as growing your own edibles – and having your children eat them – so how about starting with some of the basic pizza and pasta topping ingredients to whet your little gardeners' appetites?

Although the annual herbs (basil and rocket) have similar growing times, tomatoes, peppers, garlic and perennials such as oregano do take a while to get going, so feel free to cheat a bit with bought produce until they're all ready for

harvesting. We also suggest starting with established seedlings, where possible.

All you need are a couple of large pots, good organic potting soil – and you're ready to go.

Tomatoes

When to plant seedlings: Late spring or summer.

How long to harvest: Two to three months.



Basil

When to plant seedlings: Early spring.

How long to harvest: Three to four weeks.



Rocket

When to plant seedlings: Early spring.

How long to harvest: Four to six weeks.



Oregano

When to plant: It's best to buy a small, already established plant from your nursery and transplant it into a large pot in spring.

How long to harvest: Three to four weeks.

Garlic

When to plant: Break up a head of garlic and plant the individual cloves root-side down in spring.

How long to harvest: Up to seven months.



Sweet peppers

When to plant seedlings: Spring.

How long to harvest: Two to three months.



#FUNFACT

October is National Pizza Month. It was created in October of 1984. It is now an annually celebrated event.

Tips



1

Plant in well-drained, organic potting soil.

2

Water the base of the plants, not the leaves.

3

Garlic and oregano need their own pots.

4

Make sure the tip of each garlic clove is just above the surface of the soil.

5

Leave plenty of room for growth.

6

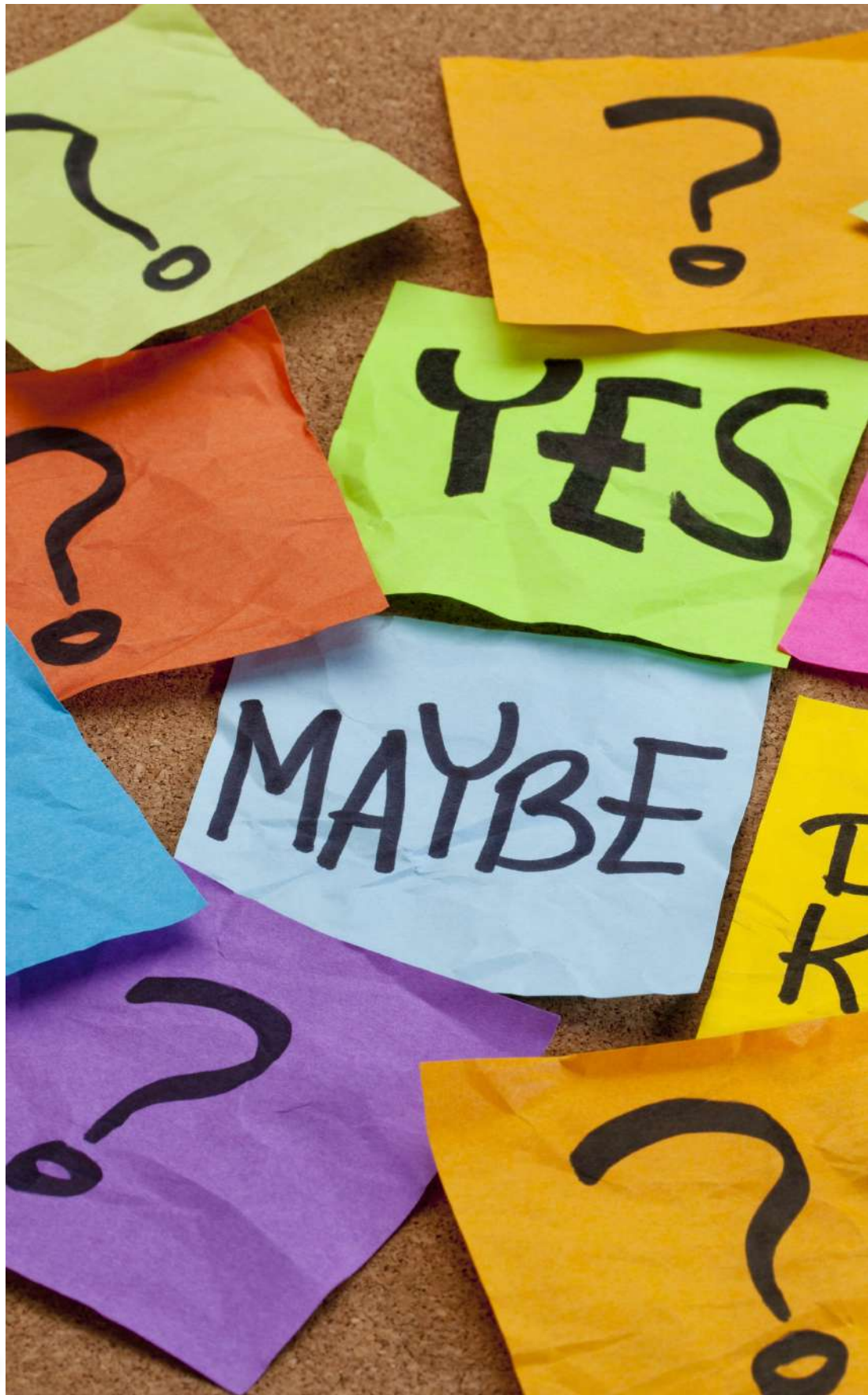
Most tomatoes need a sturdy trellis or fence to climb up.

7

Roma tomatoes make the yummiest pizza and pasta sauces.

How to choose the right curriculum

When a family decides to homeschool, one of the first questions they ask is: 'What's the *best* curriculum?' In fact, this should be one of the *last* questions they ask, writes homeschooling consultant **Wendy Young**



There are many considerations to be made before the first rand is spent.

Many parents who're new to homeschooling take what's most familiar to them; perhaps what they're used to from their own school days, or what they see a friend doing. It could also be an advert that seems to offer all the bells and whistles. But how will you know what's right for you?

Here are my top tips for choosing the right curriculum for your family:

1 Child knowledge

Learning styles are just one consideration. To be honest, most new research shows that all children learn across the spectrum. Some may favour being read to and others prefer doing projects, but either can learn in the other's preference. What's more important is knowing your children's interests, their hearts, their hopes and dreams. This means not rushing into buying a curriculum, but taking your time and really getting to know your children.

2 Family focus

Here you consider what you, as a family, are about. Are you a missionary family? Are you a family with special-needs children? Do you have one child or six? Do you have a small business or part-time job that needs to be considered?

Perhaps you want to travel more. All these issues need to be taken into account when choosing a programme, so don't just grab what's most familiar, but consider what will work in your home.

3 Goals

What are your long-term goals for your family?

What are your children's goals for their own lives? The answer may only become clearer as they get older, but if you want them to be self-employed, you should look for a curriculum and resources that will aid you in this goal. If they want to be doctors or engineers, they'll need a matric certificate to enter university. But we all know that every adult needs to be able to read, write and do maths – the three Rs – and this is generally the first thing parents should settle on. Then take the time to figure out the other curriculum elements with your children.

'We all know that every adult needs to be able to read, write and do maths – the three Rs – and this is generally the first thing parents should settle on.'



4

Cost

This is an important factor because, in general, when one parent remains home to educate the children, there's only one income-earner and budgets can be tight. Planning in advance can make all the difference if you know what your particular budget is. You can also buy programmes in stages, specifically if you choose an eclectic style of home education. By starting with the three Rs, you can add other subjects as your budget allows.

#FUNFACT

The number of homeschooled students has doubled to approximately 300 000 since the start of Covid-19.

5

Philosophy

Research which home-school philosophy appeals to you. There are many differing schools of thought and these are spread on a spectrum from school-at-home (CAPS) to unschooling styles. Briefly, they are: Literature-Based, Unit Study, Textbook, Unschooling, Accelerated, Catholic, Classical, Delight-Directed and Charlotte Mason. Each one has strengths and weaknesses, but in counselling many parents, I've found that school-at-home programmes aren't always in the best interests of the children, as there's very little freedom for



self-discovery and a parent who isn't trained in the CAPS system can quickly find themselves overwhelmed.

Time available

6

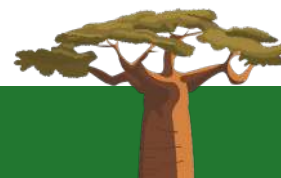
Do you have many children? Perhaps you work part-

time? Do your children pursue many sports activities and have other co-op classes? These time constraints need to be considered when preparing to purchase any curriculum so that you don't overburden yourself or place your children in a situation where they have no joy in learning.

Part of choosing a curriculum is finding the right tools to build up your children's weaknesses so that they can achieve an acceptable standard; then allowing their strengths to develop into highly honed skills. Currently in South Africa, we aren't confined to a school-at-home approach. We have the advantage of tailoring a programme to suit our children's true needs and we should take advantage of this so that we can embrace the heart of homeschooling. This is much less about textbooks, grades and test marks and more about raising strong, confident children who'll be clear and focused on their direction in life.

MAKE

things
Happen



DID YOU KNOW? The largest succulents (baobab trees) in the world are found in South Africa.



New ADvTECH school offering set to revolutionise online education

Opening its virtual doors to learners from Grade R to Grade 9, from January 2021, ADvTECH's new online offering, Evolve Online School (Evolve), will change the face of online schooling in South Africa.

'In this rapidly changing society, the one-size-fits-all method of teaching no longer makes any sense,' says principal Colin Northmore. 'Evolve starts by answering the question: how can we make learning an adventure for each child?'

Evolve combines a user-experience focus with a trendsetting curriculum mapping system, developed at MIT, to personalise each child's learning experience. Using the latest research, each child's learning journey will be designed based on exclusive subject and skill maps.

Students will be placed within subjects according to their abilities, letting them progress faster where they're gifted and work at a more deliberate pace to master content they find more challenging. The result is that each student's learning experience is tailored to their specific needs and they're encouraged to grow at a pace that suits their ability and enthusiasm.

'There'll be a strong focus on foundational, social and emotional learning skills. Our team of life coaches will focus exclusively on these skills. Our children are growing up in a world very different from the one in which



we grew up. Things that we, as adults, deal with and take in our stride, they're already facing at a very young age. Our life coaches will play a very important role in teaching students how to deal with issues such as stress and anxiety, and help them develop coping mechanisms, resilience and a growth mindset,' adds Northmore.

Evolve will make use of the following:

- **Diagnostic testing** to determine the exact level of proficiency of a student before

placement and during the educational journey.

- **Asynchronous learning** so that learners can move through content at their own pace and according to their own proficiency. Students will also have direct access to their teachers, who'll facilitate extra activation classes.
- **Synchronous learning**, where our students will also be able to attend live interactive classes, making this a true online school.
- **Socialisation opportunities** with academies, studios and day camps monthly so that students can meet other 'Evolvers' and get green time to balance their screen time.

Now enrolling for 2021.

The school will cater for Grades R-9 from January 2021. Grades 10-12 will be phased in from 2022. ADvTECH is Africa's largest private education provider. Its schools division includes iconic brands such as Crawford Schools, Trinityhouse and Abbotts.

Visit: www.evolveonline.co.za for more information or email: info@evolveonline.co.za.

A wealth of wonders



Age gaps

Need ideas for home-schooling children of different ages and stages? Watch this great webinar at the popular international non-profit hslda.org

Caring through Covid

Alateen celebrates its 64th Global Birthday this year. While Alateen groups around the country used to meet face to face, youngsters between nine and 17 can now attend virtual meetings – regardless of location. For young people affected by someone else's drinking, Alateen provides a safe place to share their own experiences and hopes, and to learn how to apply the principles of the Al-Anon/Alateen programme to their lives. www.alanongauteng.co.za

Lessons to learn, events to enjoy, videos to inspire

Storytime in the city

Fabulous news for Joburg families! Bridge Books and the Literary District host storytelling gatherings for children every Saturday at 10h30. 98 Commissioner Street, Marshalltown. www.bridgebooks.co.za



What a find!

We've just discovered that you can gain free access to all the content of the internationally recognised Homeschooling Global Summit: useful ideas, links and excellent resources about homeschooling, curated by their fantastic team every two weeks. To register, go to www.homeschooling-summit.com

Cape Town Science Centre

The Mother City is SPRINGing into action at the Cape Town Science Centre and opening to the general public.

R80

Saturday, 30 October – *Earthlings & Space Things*

Saturday, 27 November – *SUPERSIZED Science*

While each Saturday will be themed, the centre will still have its regular features such as the AstroTrek Virtual Reality Exhibition, What Is It Used For? Mini-Exhibition, Science Shows, Camera Obscura tours, Gyroscopic rides and more! Book tickets [here](#)



We love Love2Learn...

...particularly its '15 tips to treasure', which include 'Give yourself nine months' and 'Modelling is more effective than mentoring'. Find more at www.love2learn.co.za

For all the newbies

Natascha Yazbek of SANHSA (South African National Homeschooling Assoc) shared this excellent video, *Brand New to Homeschooling Part 1*, and it's so informative, we just had to share it with you. Watch it [here](#)

You should see this

The Kids Should See This is a Webby Award-winning collection of more than 5 000 child-friendly videos, curated for teachers and parents who want to share smarter, more meaningful media in the learning space. It's free and available to everyone. www.thekidsshouldseethis.com



Cinderella Pantomime 2021

From Friday, 5 November 2021
R290-R410

Once upon a time a girl named Cinderella lived with her two stepsisters. Poor Cinderella had to work hard all day long so the others could rest. One day, big news came to town. The king and queen were going to have a ball! It was time for Prince Charming to find a bride. Producers Joburg Theatre and Bernard Jay bring the Fairy Godmother of All Pantomimes back to the stage of The Mandela at Joburg Theatre. Book tickets [here](#).

Resourceful

teacha! is not just for traditional school teachers, its resources are also great for homeschoolers – and are remarkably affordable. Take a look here: www.teacha.co.za/category/resources



Snakes alive

Did you know that the African Snakebite Institute in Muldersdrift offers Kids' Snake Awareness courses for children aged five to 12? Your young animal-lover will learn all about our slithery friends in an entirely safe – and memorable – way. Contact Bianca on fin@asiorg.co.za for dates of the next course.

Jolly Roger Pirate Ship

R100-R200

Ahoy, me hearties!

The *Jolly Roger* is the only authentic pirate ship in South Africa. It can sail in most weather conditions and is fitted with an onboard generator to supply both lights and music. Clean ablution facilities are available on board, along with comfortable seating and leisure areas. Book tickets [here](#)



Wise words

'Our aim is not merely to make the child understand, and still less to force him to memorise, but so to touch his imagination as to enthuse him to his innermost core.'
– Maria Montessori

Managing longer words

Children can often read small words, but struggle with big ones. To help them read longer words, two things need to be explicitly taught, advises our reading specialist, **Marian Bailey**

Firstly, don't expect your child to memorise long words. Memorisation is the way poor readers read. Instead, help them find smaller words, or word parts in the bigger word, then take each chunk and decode it before putting the chunks back together to read the longer word.

A long word or a multi-syllable word is defined as a word with

more than one syllable (a syllable is part of a word and must have a vowel in it). A long word is, in fact, smaller words or word parts which are joined to make a new word. Therefore, to be able to read multi-syllable words, a child should be able to do the following:

1 Read real and nonsense consonant vowel consonant (CVC) words. An example of a real CVC word is *red*. An example of a nonsense CVC word is *nop*.

2 Be able to count syllables in words (this falls under phonological awareness drills and should be practised from a young age). **Hint:** When counting syllables in words, use

games to make it fun, but don't use the traditional clapping syllable method, as this can be challenging for some children because the clapping noise muffles the pronunciation of each syllable. Instead, try these ideas: say the word *lovely*. Your child repeats the word back to you as a whole word first – *lovely*. Then ask your child to chop/jump/hop/drum/stamp the syllables *love – ly*.

3 Be able to name the vowels (terminology is key: teach your child what a vowel is and what a consonant is).

4 Know and be able to look for a suffix and a prefix.

'Bei
read
CVC v
key t
long



Being able to read nonsense CVC words is the key to reading longer words. Why? Often multi-syllable words are nonsense words that, when combined, become real words. Therefore practising reading nonsense words is preparing a child to read multi-syllable words. Practising decoding and blending CVC nonsense words during the blending drill using sound cards will equip an emerging reader to access longer words early on, which will mean less guessing.

For example, the word *volcanic* is made up of two nonsense words and one real word:

vol can ic.

There are six types of syllables and it's helpful to teach your child each type and how to use it to read and spell longer words. If they don't have in-depth knowledge of syllables, they'll guess, or look at picture clues, or skip a longer word altogether.

The six types

Closed

Syllables that have a single vowel followed by a consonant, then a vowel which makes it a short sound (eg, *vet*).

Open

Syllables that have a single vowel and end with a vowel. The vowel will make its long sound (eg, *baby*).



Vowel consonant e (final/silent e)

Syllables that have a single vowel with a silent e at the end (eg, *cupcake*).

R-controlled

Syllables in which an r follows the vowel(s). The r 'controls' the vowel sound (eg, *purple*).

Vowel teams

Syllables with two vowels that act as a team to create one sound (eg, *rainbow*).

Consonant +le

Syllables that have a consonant followed by an le. Found at end of a word (eg, *table*).

Start with longer words that have only short vowels, then move

on to a silent e at the end, then to vowel teams. To be able to access vowel teams in multi-syllable words, a child must be able to read a vowel team in a single syllable word – eg, to read *pain* before we expect them to read *constrain*.

Develop strong reading habits in the early years by insisting that your child decodes every word (no guessing) and incorporating daily phonological awareness drills into literacy time.

Please feel free to contact me on marian@raisingreaders.co.za if your child needs further literacy support.



Being able to read nonsense words is the key to reading longer words.'

Active Home Education Institute

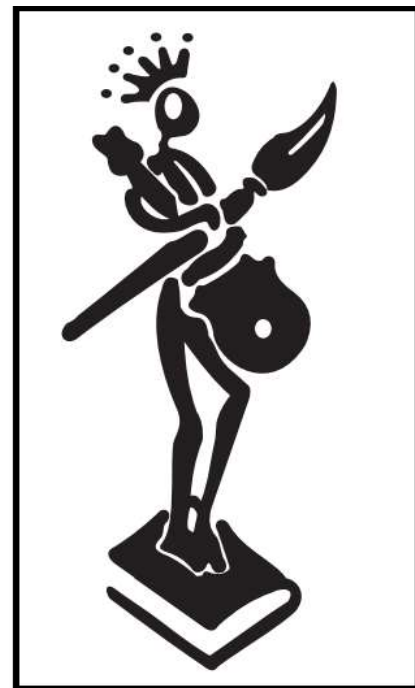
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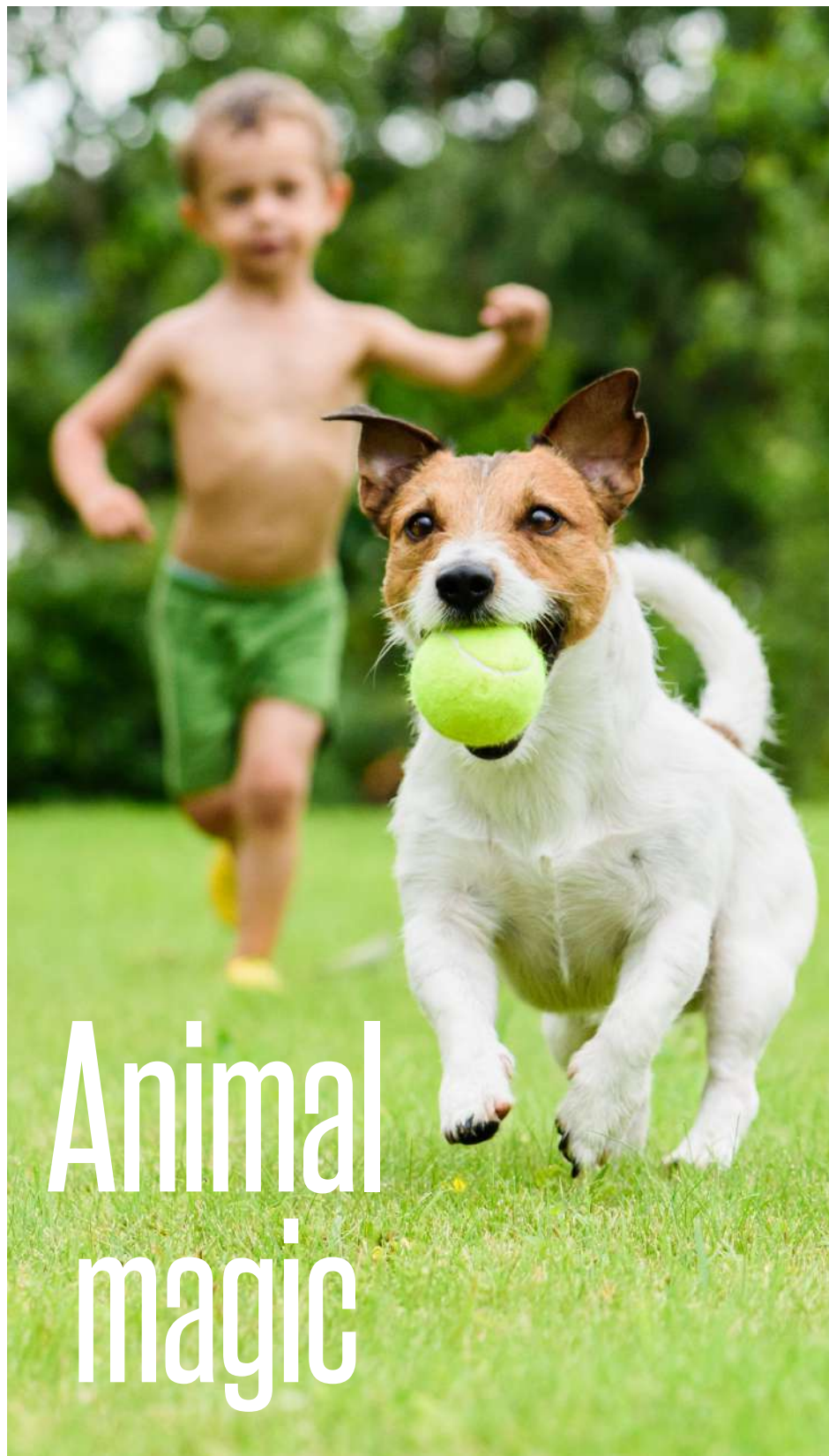
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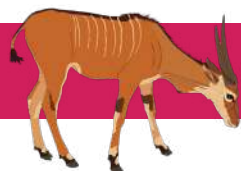
Animal magic

There's so much that children can learn from animals – and from caring for them, writes mom of three **Adri Viviers**

If you grew up with a family pet, it's hard to imagine life without one. Ever since I can remember, I've had animals around me. My mother has an incredible heart for animals and always seemed to find one in need – whether it was a stray dog which had been hit by a car, a cat whose owners had left it behind after moving or a bird with an injured wing. Maybe she didn't find them: maybe they found her – and she always ended up keeping them. Many of my childhood memories are of petting, playing with or even sharing my secrets with our family dog.

Today my husband and I live in Louis Trichardt with our three beautiful children. Our dog Browser and two cats, Enzo and Trooper, are all valued members of our family.

I've been volunteering at Louis Trichardt's SPCA for just over six years now. It's the only SPCA branch in the Vhembe District in Limpopo.



DID YOU KNOW? South Africa is home to the largest and the slowest antelope in the world – the eland.

Its committee comprises a group of dynamic people who gladly dedicate their time to helping animals in need and each member brings their particular passion to the team. My role is to visit schools in our district, often accompanied by the branch's Senior Inspector, Lawrence Khodobo, committee member Alicia Thomas and her dog Quest, to tell kids about the work we do at the SPCA and teach them how to care for their pets regularly. We also have schools (kindergartens to high schools) visit us on a regular basis. They're given the opportunity to interact with some of the animals in our care. Some of the classes who've visited our facility have included autistic pupils and the interaction



between them and the animals was very special to witness.

It's impossible not to see the delight on a child's face when they interact with animals, but there's much more to the bond between kids and pets than most of us realise. Yes, children love the furry cuddles and enjoy being licked by a purring cat – but research shows that animal interactions can actually improve children's

social interactions and can help them develop positive values. These include:

- **Respect** (children learn that animals need to be treated with care and compassion).
- **Empathy** (kids learn to empathise with their pets and respond to their needs).
- **Responsibility** (children learn accountability and that they're depended upon by a living thing).
- **Self-esteem** (children know that no matter how bad a day they're having, a pet is always there to 'listen' and be a source of affection).
- **Overcoming fears** (children who grow up with pets are generally less fearful of animals).
- **Appreciation of nature** (through pets, children gain insights into wild and domestic animals).



#FUNFACT

A cat can jump as much as seven times its height.



Interactions with animals also help develop social skills in children with disabilities or those who've been traumatised. (Interestingly, nowadays pets are often also taken to old age homes and hospitals, where they seem to have a powerful healing effect, both physically and emotionally.)



If you can't have a pet in your home, there are still many ways your children can go on this learning journey. One is by lending a hand at an animal shelter and/or care programmes/project in your area. If you don't know where your local one is, try enquiring on social media. Volunteering with your child at an animal shelter could also be valuable bonding time for both of you.

Given the responsibility of looking after a living creature, children are encouraged to grow into caring, social and confident

adults. Through animal experiences, we become more curious, respectful, sensitive and appreciative of all living things.

'Interactions with animals also help develop social skills in children with disabilities or those who've been traumatised.'



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Futurologists predict that 65% of today's Grade 4 learners will eventually hold jobs that don't yet exist. So, how do you prepare your child for this changing scenario? Learning specialist and Co-Director of StudySmart, **Dr Deon van Wyk**, investigates



The learning family

Plasticity is the capacity of the brain to change with learning, but this change takes time, so children need to exercise the inherent abilities of their brains in order to learn new skills, build a better memory and improve processing speed. This may sound horribly complicated, but it's not.

Let me tell you a story.

Abraham Lincoln (Abe) was born in 1809 on the largely unsettled wild frontier of America. He grew up in a one-roomed log cabin without doors or windows, no flooring and little furniture. When he was about seven, a school opened 14km away

and his mother Nancy insisted that he attend school (it took him two-and-a-half to three hours to walk each way). This didn't last long and Abe estimated that his time in school totalled only one year. Nancy was illiterate, but she realised the importance of reading. Even though she had to cope with harsh circumstances and few amenities, by sheer will, she instilled in Abe a love of reading.

Abe's mother died when he was still young, but fortunately his stepmother continued his education. Though the family had little money for paper,

'Learning entails certain skills and a positive attitude.'



pencils or books, his stepmom did what she could to get a few things so that Abe could read and write. His love of reading became well known and neighbours remembered how he would walk for miles to borrow a book, or read while walking behind a plough. Both Nancy and Abe's stepmother themselves became versatile in this new skill called literacy and made it part of their lives – and so this homeschooled boy grew up to become a principled leader who guided America through its darkest time and changed the course of history.

Note that this isn't about study skills, but rather about *learning* skills, making them part of your mindset, changing your attitude and becoming a learning family.

So, what's different about learning families?

- They have inquisitive minds. They never stop asking: 'Why? How? When?'
- They don't need additional time to become learning families. They realise that it's a change in attitude and a way of living that can be practised anywhere, anytime – for example, when on holiday, while having lunch or dinner, when driving in a car, when visiting a museum, etc.
- They experience joy in discovery and understanding and are



continuously amazed by the intricacies and complexities of life and the world around them.

Learning entails certain skills and a positive attitude. Both skills and attitude take time to develop, which gives homeschooling families a strong advantage: you and your children are often together over a very long period, putting you in the best possible position to teach them these skills and foster a positive attitude. Make it your own, encourage it in your children and it will generalise to your children's schoolwork.

Remember, it's easier to build strong children than repair broken adults and the benefits are huge:

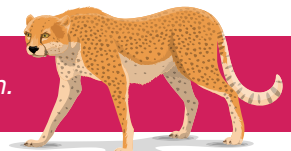
- No more conflict over schoolwork.
- Children are better prepared for future challenges.



- It's fun and fulfilling to share knowledge.
- It's beautiful, amazing and rewarding to experience children discovering their personal intellectual capital and fully applying it.

I urge you to say 'yes' to becoming a learning family. In upcoming issues of *SAH*, I'll share more practical advice on what homeschooling parents can do to become real learning families.

DID YOU KNOW? Lion, wildebeest, cheetah and springbok are four of the seven fastest mammals on earth.



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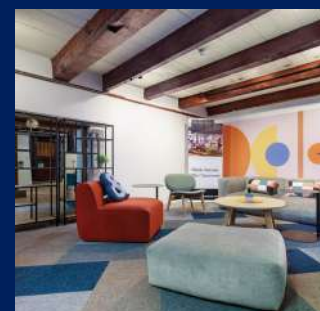


Boutique
learning campuses

Dunkeld Johannesburg



Newlands Cape Town



ST STITHIANS
ONLINE SCHOOL

IN COLLABORATION WITH  VALENTURE INSTITUTE

St Stithians Online School's Boutique Campuses combine online learning and in-person connection in a modern, collaborative space

Online doesn't have to mean out of touch. St Stithians Online School offers its students the opportunity to learn successfully anywhere, anytime, and its physical space at Valentre Institute's Boutique Campuses is making waves online and in person.

St Stithians Online School's academic service provider, Valentre Institute, created the blended learning environment for students needing a safe and supervised physical space while safely engaging in their online academics.



SA's first blended learning space for online high school students



As a separate offering from the students' online learning, the Boutique Campuses boast a campus manager, a learning coach and a learning facilitator who assist with daily needs and promote self-directed learning that helps students along their online high school career.

Beyond academics, students can enjoy a multi-purpose space to collaborate or enjoy lunch, a recreation space (to catch up with classmates while playing table tennis/relaxing on a bean bag), as well as a host of extracurricular activities based on student interest.

A very exciting part of the Boutique Campus experience is the gamification of students' behaviour management using Classcraft – and it's perfect for the new-age kid. Classcraft is a whole new way of looking at behaviour that encourages students to engage in their learning, wrapped in a fun interactive tool that lets them design characters and gain points.

The blended learning offering has two modern campuses: one in Dunkeld, Johannesburg and the other in Newlands, Cape Town. Each campus brings a unique flair of funky and from the minute the kids walk through the doors, wearing their complimentary branded SSOS hoodies, they can enjoy a spacious, collaborative learning environment.

Sharing his campus experience, SSOS Junior High student Stephen-Luke Chellan explains: 'The main reason for me moving from a bricks-and-mortar school to an online school such as St Stithians Online School is because I prefer the environment and this way of learning. Something that highly attracted me to this school is the fact that it's an online school with a campus, so I still have a strong social life. This is one of the highest benefits of SSOS.'

For parents and students looking for a safe, supervised physical space with a flexible schedule, the Boutique Campus is just the thing. Each campus offers:

- A combination of virtual learning and in-person support and experiences.
- Covid-19 monitoring – access control with temperature checks.
- Academic studies completed online with multiple live classes daily from the country's best teachers, supported by weekly mentor catch-ups.
- An on-demand transport service provider enabling students to travel to and from campuses when needed.



- Student support from an on-site campus manager, learning coach and learning facilitator.
- Access to dedicated spaces, including learning spaces, recreational spaces and multi-purpose spaces.
- An additional on-site extracurricular programme.

The Boutique Campuses provide the best of a unique blended learning environment, while providing parents with the flexibility and security to know that their children are being taken care of.

Each Boutique Campus can accommodate a maximum of 60 students, ensuring a small and intimate learning environment where students can have fun, collaborate and receive the attention they need. More campus locations will be announced as interest increases around South Africa.

This new learning normal works for the student, rather than the school. An online offering built on a rock-solid foundation spanning 68 years of tradition, values and principles.

Is this the right fit for your child?

The Boutique Campus monthly access fee is an additional R2 500.

St Stithians Online High School will welcome its second cohort in January 2022. The online school offers an international curriculum with International GCSEs, AS and A-level qualifications accredited by Pearson Edexcel to students from Grades 8-13. Fees per month start at R7 150.

For more information, visit: https://bit.ly/SSOSBC_SAHomeschoolers or quote 'SAH' when enquiring for your child on: admissions@ssos.valentureonline.com.

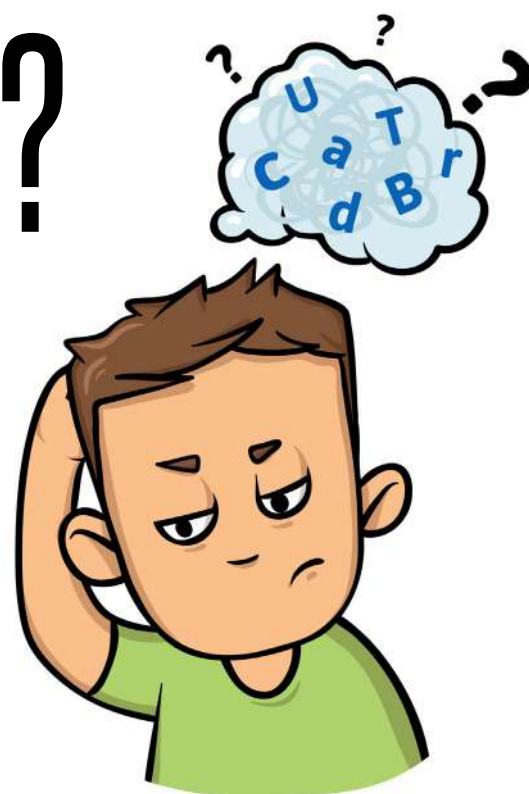
Is your child lazy?

If your child seems to be distracted or unmotivated all the time, it might be time to learn more about executive functioning skills, writes **Dalena van der Westhuizen** of BrainAbility

Executive function challenges are almost always interpreted as laziness – but although laziness might play a role in a small percentage of children, for most of them it's usually weak executive functioning skills that are the problem.

Most kids want to succeed, but just don't know how.

Here are a few examples of executive functioning weaknesses:



What I would see	Why it happens	Skill needed for this task
Refuses to do homework or always struggles to get started on most tasks	Doesn't know how to get started; finds it difficult to get starting points in processes	Initiation
Easily distracted	Lacks the strategies to maintain focus and resist distractions	Sustained attention
Always late, usually hands in/ finishes work past the due date	Doesn't have the strategies for being aware of time	Time management
Regularly forgets or loses personal belongings	Doesn't have the systems to keep track of items like books, shoes, keys, pens, etc	Organisation
Procrastinates, has panic/anxiety at the last minute	Doesn't know how to break tasks into smaller, manageable tasks/ chunks and sequence the work that needs to be done	Planning

What is executive function and why is it important?

Executive functioning skills are a set of abilities essential for thinking through and completing tasks. They're the skills that allow us to problem-solve, initiate and complete tasks, and sustain our attention through the completion of a task.

Executive function is essentially our ability to 'get things done'. They guide everything we do and are necessary for tasks such as getting dressed and ready for the day, starting and completing homework, or making sandwiches for lunch. They're needed for every



multi-step activity we do, every day of our lives.

Executive functioning is initiating a task, adjusting to problems and negotiating obstacles, while organising and prioritising all the steps and details.

The following are cognitive processes that generally make up our executive functioning skills. These skills are essential for learning, behaviour and development:

- ✓ **Attention**
- ✓ **Impulse control**
- ✓ **Emotional control**
- ✓ **Flexible thinking**
- ✓ **Working memory**
- ✓ **Self-monitoring**
- ✓ **Planning and prioritising**
- ✓ **Task initiation**
- ✓ **Organisation**

All these skills work together and impact each other.

Aspects of executive functioning skills are developed from a very young age, then extended and further developed throughout childhood and into the teen years, even into adulthood. And the good news is that they can be strengthened. Try the following strategies:

To help with task initiation

- Break down tasks
- Identify the task
- Set mini-goals
- Use a timer
- Use a schedule (try a picture schedule for younger kids)
- Use time-boxing (eg blocking out a specific time for certain tasks)
- Use a checklist



To help with working memory

- Take notes
- Use mnemonics
- Practise through rehearsal
- To-do lists
- Task sequencing lists

To help with organisation

- Develop routines and stick to them
- Break long-term tasks into smaller tasks with deadlines
- Colour-code books, folders, workbooks, etc
- Use a calendar to keep track of appointments, assignments, tests, events, etc



To help with impulse control

- Reduce clutter
- Reduce or increase time to complete tasks
- Act out situations beforehand (role-play)
- Use a visual schedule
- Break projects into smaller tasks

To help with planning and prioritising

- Allow opportunities to plan simple tasks (getting dressed, making a birthday card, making a bed, making a sandwich, etc)
- Talk about the most important steps of a task – what should be done before the next step can be taken
- Draw/Doodle the steps to be followed for a specific task
- Create a mental map of a multiple-step task/project

When strategies alone aren't enough, or the number of strategies required is overwhelming, it's time to dig deeper. You might want to consider a cognitive assessment to pinpoint strengths, weaknesses and specific learning needs. Your child's individual cognitive profile will highlight what needs to be done to permanently strengthen weak skills.

Happy reading until the next issue!

'Executive function is essentially our ability to 'get things done'.'





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Bullied to beauty

1. Shudu Finds her Magic
(Jacana Media Children's Books, in partnership with the author)

'The one lesson I learnt is that when something bad is happening to you, it is important to speak to an adult whom you trust about it. This could be a parent, a family member, a teacher or an elder. Remember that being bullied is not your fault. There is nothing wrong with you. Nobody should have to go through what I went through.' – Miss South Africa, Shudufhadzo Musida

In this courageous and beautiful book, Musida tells the story of

her upbringing as an outgoing girl in a small village named Ha-Vhangani. She is surrounded by a loving extended family. However, things take a turn for the worse when her mother gets a new job and they move to Mpumalanga. At her new school, Musida is bullied by her classmates. Read how she overcomes the bullying and sadness, and grows into a adolescent, then an adult who's learnt to love herself.

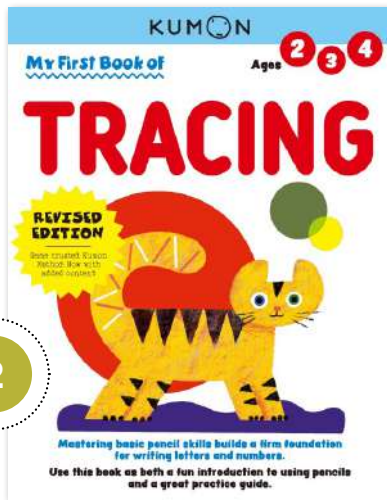
The gorgeous illustrations are by Chantelle and Burgen Thorne.

Shudu Finds her Magic is also available in the following languages, making it the perfect read for second-language pupils:



Afrikaans (*Shudu Vind Haar Sprinkel*), Sesotho (*Shudu o Sibolla Boikgetho ba Hae*), Venda (*Shudu u Wana Vhutolo Hawe*), isiXhosa (*uShudu u Fumanisa Ukuba UnoMlingo*) and isiZulu (*uShudu Uthola Umlingo Wakhe*).

DID YOU KNOW? There are only six floral kingdoms on the planet and South Africa is home to one of them – Fynbos.



2

Learning to write

2. Tracing (Kumon)

The first of these Kumon workbooks will introduce your child to basic pencil skills in the most enjoyable way, starting with relatively easy tracing and gradually leading to more complex paths to follow. Each page is so delightfully illustrated that your little one will probably nag for 'just one more'!



3

3. Uppercase Letters and Lowercase Letters (Kumon)

The Kumon Method is a learning system designed to help each child realise their full potential, without all the usual frustration. These two workbooks allow your child to master each step of forming letters on their own, before moving on to the next. Most importantly, they're so much fun that they won't even feel like 'schoolwork'!

CHALK ONE UP WITH SA Homeschooling's 'CHALKBOARD!'



If you have your own homeschooling service, whether it be social activities, caregiving services, gardening for kids' programmes, extramurals, educational games/puzzles, outdoor activity programmes and the like, then SA Homeschooling's 'Chalkboard' pages are the perfect way to get them promoted. And at an exceptionally affordable rate with fantastic exposure!

**CONTACT US
FOR MORE INFORMATION**

JENNY jenny@isikhova.co.za

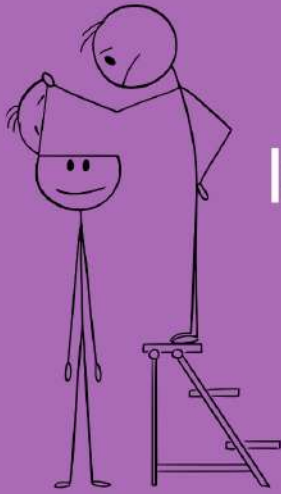
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Get creative & WIN!

SA homeschoolers! We're thrilled to announce our 2021 Children's Creative Writing Competition.

This is a wonderful opportunity for your child to showcase their writing skills and creativity in an exciting and fun way. Entries can be either fiction or non-fiction and there's no specific topic.

The competition will run from this issue through to Issue 7.

The winning piece from each age group below will be published in the subsequent issue (we will amend any minor spelling or grammar errors). Each will win a terrific book prize from Jonathan Ball Publishers, our competition partners.

A grand 'surprise' prize for each age category will then be selected and announced in Issue 9.

SAH's 2021
Children's
Creative Writing
Competition

HOW TO ENTER

There are three age categories:

- 8-10 years
- 11-13 years
- 14-17 years

The submission must not exceed 400 words and should be written either in a Word doc or the body of the email. This competition is open to subscribed readers only. If you've not yet subscribed, please email: sahomeschooling@isikhova.co.za with 'subscribe' in the subject line.

Email sahomeschooling@isikhova.co.za with 'Creative Writing – Your Child's Name' in the subject line, along with the following in the body of the email:

- Your full name
- Contact number
- Your child's name
- Your child's age
- Title of written piece

Closing date for entries:
11 November 2021

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JonathanBallPublishers

PAN MACMILLAN
SOUTH AFRICA

Creative writing competition second-round winners

Once again, children have proven that they understand the power of the pen. What a difficult task it was finding the best of the best! And don't forget, it's not too late to enter your child's writing in the final round of this great competition

Change begins at the End of Your Comfort Zone

By Zaibaa Rawat, age 13

Starting over... It's something I used to find hard to do. You know, saying goodbye to everything and everyone you've grown to love.

I didn't know what to say when my mother said we were moving, I didn't know how to react when she told me that she and Dad were separating, and I definitely didn't know what to do when I found out that my best friends had betrayed me. I hadn't realised how much could happen until today.

I was always told I showed too many emotions. Too much sadness. Too much anger. Too much negativity. The only thing I heard was: 'Stop being so dramatic!' and 'You're too sensitive.' But that day, after everything happened, I smiled. Smiled at how ironic everything

was. I'd always thought my best friends would be there for me. I'd always thought my parents were happy.

I remember something my grandma once said: 'All things bad for you will, one way or another, come to an end.' I finally understood what she meant.

The next day, packing my things wasn't hard at all. Learning to accept and move on is something a lot of people struggle to do, but at that moment, I felt relieved. I'm not sure why, but I did.

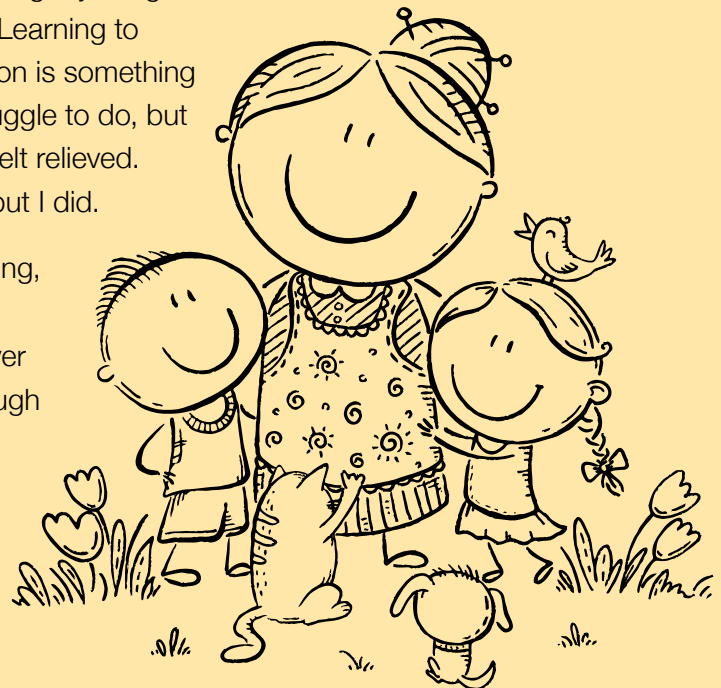
This unknown feeling, that I didn't know I needed, settled over me. Making me laugh at how right my grandma was.

'Once those bad things you didn't know about

leave, you'll have this – how do I put it? – relieved feeling. When you first see the bad things leave, it will hurt. I'm not going to lie. But once it's gone, I'm telling you, sweetie, you'll be lighter. Happier.' She really was a wise woman.

And that's when I realised change doesn't feel that hard.

The end



What the judges said

Zaibaa's story really grabbed our hearts, taking us back to when we were teens suffering through the changes and challenges that life threw at us. Zaibaa writes with great sensitivity and depth.

The Samuels Gang and the Lost Tiger: Part 1

By Kevahn Samuels, age 11

It was another beautiful morning in Los Angeles, California. The Samuels gang were on their summer break. They were off to an exciting day at the Disneyland Park.

'I am so excited!' said Ciara.

'Me too!' said Kevin.

'Yeah, whoo!' said Calvin.

Ciara said: 'Come on, Calvin, don't be so sarcastic.'

Just as she said that, the phone screeched out a crazy sound. 'Hello, this is the Samuels gang. Who am I speaking to?' It was the president of the United States of America.

'Guys, Disneyland will have to wait – we have a mission!'

12:48 am: President's villa

Okay, so that must be the back entrance to the president's house.

'Let's swim across,' said Calvin.

'Wait, Calvin – look at what's in the water,' said Kevin. Indeed, he was right: there lay one of the most

beautiful, but dangerous tigers in the world. 'Wow, that's an albino tiger! How did the president get one of them? They're one of the rarest species alive,' he said.

'That's cool and all, but how are we going to get past it?' asked Ciara.

'Get out your ziplines. We can ride them over the water without waking up the tiger.'

'Good idea, Calvin,' said Ciara.

They put their plan to action, but as they got in, they came face to face with the president's bodyguards.

'Let's take them down, ninja-style,' said Kevin.

The gang was shredding the bodyguards to pieces, until a voice said: 'That's enough now.' It was

the president. 'You guys are pretty good,' he said.

'Why did you call us here?' asked Calvin.

'I need your help,' said the president. 'Are you in?'

'Sure,' they all said.

'A few days ago, some guys tried to break into my house. My precious tigers were there to try to protect me. They didn't take anything besides my beautiful tigress, Elena. I know you saw a tiger in the pool, but that was Elena's cub, Zara.'

'Don't worry, Mr President – we'll get her back,' said Ciara.

'That's good. Start packing your bags, boys and girl. We're going to Brazil!'

The end



What the judges said

We all love a good cliff-hanger – and, boy, can Kevahn deliver! It's real 007 stuff, with just the right amount of snappy dialogue and action.

A Night of Horrors**By Kimaya Valabh, age 10**

On a cold, dark night after I walked back home, I entered my house and had a relaxing hot shower. After an exhausting day, I threw myself lazily on my bed and drifted off to sleep. I was sleeping peacefully until I heard a loud THUD in my backyard. It was aliens.

I was getting abducted

By the creepy aliens in my yard

I saw the blue light

Then decided let's fight

But then they came to my room window, took me and fled

'Oh, someone help me!' I pled

Then I saw my dad coming along

But it was just another alien singing a song

'AAH!' I scream

The alien was as shiny as a moonbeam

We travelled a short distance and they dropped me onto the ground in the spine-chilling woods! I was trembling. Suddenly, there was a bloodcurdling AWOOO! 'Hello,'

said a wolf sweetly, and he trotted away. Thereafter there was a flash of blinding light and there before me stood a glittery, mystical unicorn. She was like one of the shimmering stars gleaming in the dark blue sky. But what distracted me from the beauty exuded by the unicorn was a thunderous CREAK. Above me appeared a spider as big as a giant. It scuttled down its silky web and captured me in its eight hairy legs. It catapulted me kilometres away.

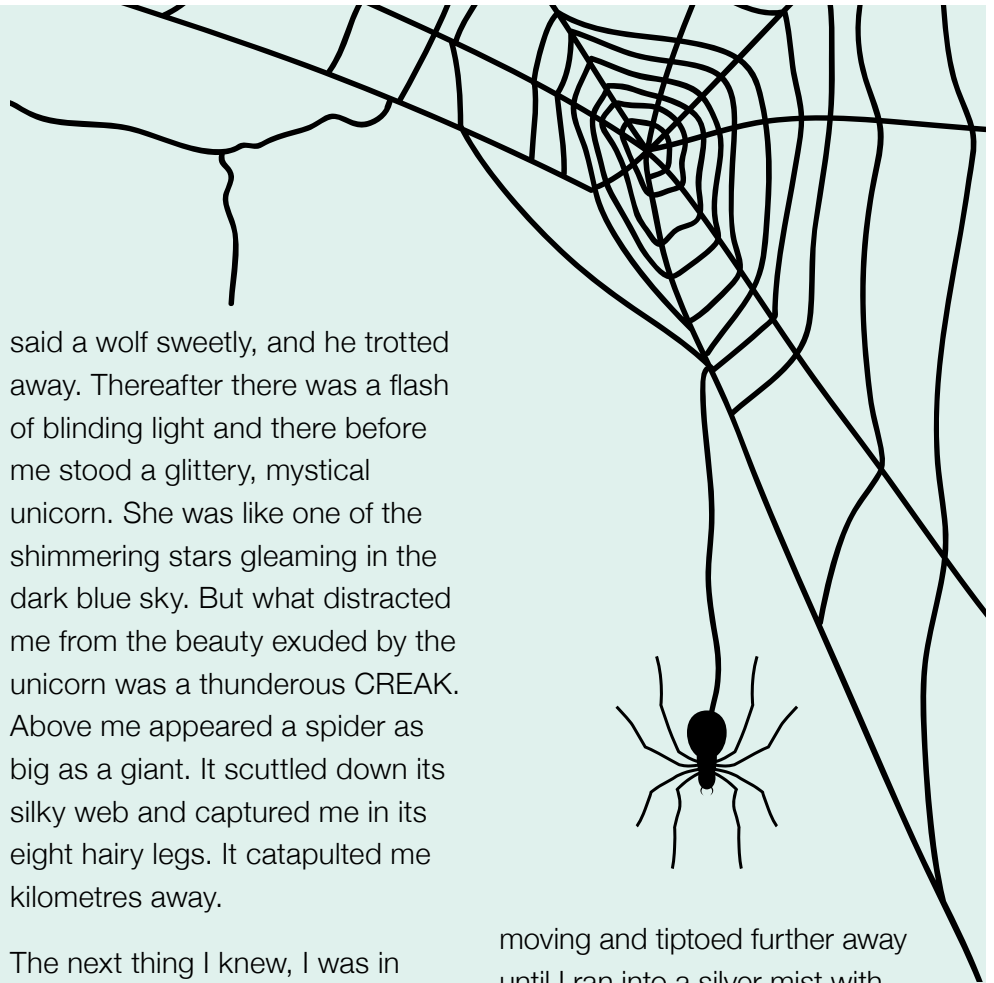
The next thing I knew, I was in a tree full of delicious berries. 'Yummy!' I thought. I was ravenous. I tasted the tempting berries. They were scrumptiously juicy. I hopped down from the tree and needed to take a break from this terrifying adventure. I sat below a beautiful willow tree. 'Oh, no!' It picked me up maliciously and started juggling with me. I could not wait to go home.

I quickly zoomed away from the whomping tree when it stopped

moving and tiptoed further away until I ran into a silver mist with faces. They were ghosts! I ran away as fast as I could.

Home sweet home. I turned the doorknob to enter my house. When I got inside, I felt a flood of relief. I was back home. I just wanted to fling myself onto my warm bed. I set foot in my room and wished that when I woke up in the morning, this would all be just a nightmare.

The end

**What the judges said**

Kimaya had us from 'The alien was as shiny as a moonbeam'. What gorgeous, creative and creepy writing! We just hope she has mostly peaceful nights from now on.

The MORE
that you read,
the MORE things
you will know.
The MORE that you
Learn,
the MORE places you'll go.

– Dr Seuss

